

Case Study : *The Two Gentlemen of Verona* by William Shakespeare

Author Background

Written by William Shakespeare likely between 1589 and 1593, *The Two Gentlemen of Verona* is widely considered to be his very first play. Because it is an early work, it is a bit rougher around the edges than his later masterpieces, but it is fascinating because it introduces themes and tropes he would perfect later—most notably, the heroine disguising herself as a boy, the clownish servant, and the conflict between friendship and romance.

NB : My dear *E-learning Members*, remember the sign “—” is like a comma “,”.

C'est-à-dire, ça remplace une virgule.

Plot Summary

Valentine and Proteus are best friends living in Verona. Valentine travels to the Duke's court in Milan to broaden his horizons, while Proteus stays behind because he is deeply in love with a woman named Julia. However, Proteus's father forces him to travel to Milan as well.

In Milan, Valentine has fallen in love with the Duke's daughter, Silvia. When Proteus arrives, he takes one look at Silvia and instantly forgets about Julia, deciding he must have Silvia for himself. To do this, Proteus betrays Valentine by telling the Duke that Valentine plans to elope with Silvia. The Duke banishes Valentine, who flees to a forest and becomes the captain of a band of outlaws.

Meanwhile, Julia disguises herself as a male page named "Sebastian" and travels to Milan, only to discover Proteus wooing Silvia. Silvia rejects Proteus and flees into the forest to find Valentine. Proteus follows her, and Julia (still in disguise) follows him. In the forest, Proteus rescues Silvia from outlaws but then attempts to force himself on her when she rejects him again. Valentine steps in, stops Proteus, and rebukes him. Proteus apologizes, and in a bizarre, controversial twist, Valentine instantly forgives his friend and offers to give Silvia to him. Hearing this, Julia faints, revealing her true identity. Proteus realizes he loves Julia after all, and the play ends with a double wedding.

Act 1 – Friendship and Separation

Valentine and Proteus are close friends in Verona.

Valentine leaves for Milan to seek honor and adventure.

Proteus stays behind because he loves Julia.

They exchange vows of friendship.

Key idea: Love and friendship are set on a collision course.

Act 2 – Love and Betrayal Begins

Proteus's father sends him to Milan.

Julia disguises herself as a boy named Sebastian and follows Proteus.

In Milan, Valentine falls in love with Silvia, the Duke's daughter.

Proteus also falls in love with Silvia and forgets Julia.

Key idea: Proteus proves unfaithful; love becomes selfish.

Act 3 – The Height of Treachery

Proteus betrays Valentine by revealing his plan to elope with Silvia.

The Duke banishes Valentine.

Proteus tries to court Silvia, who rejects him and remains loyal to Valentine.

Julia (disguised) becomes Proteus's servant and witnesses his betrayal.

Key idea: Friendship is destroyed by jealousy and lust.

Act 4 – Outlaws and Confusion

Valentine joins a band of outlaws and becomes their leader.

Silvia tries to escape to find Valentine.

Proteus follows her.

Julia continues to suffer silently.

Key idea: Disguise and misunderstanding drive the plot.

Act 5 – Resolution

Proteus tries to force Silvia's love.

Valentine intervenes.

Proteus repents when he sees Julia faint and reveal her identity.

Friendship is restored.

Valentine and Silvia reunite.

Proteus returns to Julia.

The Duke forgives Valentine.

Key idea: Forgiveness and reconciliation conclude the comedy.

Characters and Characterization

- **Valentine:** The classic romantic. He starts out mocking love but falls deeply for Silvia. He is honorable and fiercely loyal to his friends, almost to a fault.
- **Proteus:** His name comes from the shape-shifting Greek god, which perfectly describes his fickle nature. He is driven by immediate passion, easily abandoning his morals, his girlfriend, and his best friend for a new crush.
- **Silvia:** Intelligent, strong-willed, and loyal. She sees right through Proteus's treachery and remains completely devoted to Valentine.
- **Julia:** Devoted and brave. She is Shakespeare's first "breeches role" (a woman dressing as a man). Her steadfast love acts as a foil to Proteus's inconstancy.
- **Launce & Crab:** Launce is Proteus's servant, providing comic relief. His dog, Crab, is notoriously unresponsive and unfeeling, which ironically highlights the emotional chaos of the human characters. IT shows a contrast between real loyalty (dog) and human betrayal.
- **Duke of Milan:** Authoritative father. He opposes Silvia's love.

Themes

- **Friendship vs. Love:** The central conflict of the play. In the Renaissance era, male friendship was often considered a higher, purer bond than romantic love, which is why Valentine's shocking offer to give Silvia to Proteus makes sense in the context of the period's ideals, even if it baffles modern audiences.

- **The Fickleness of Youth**: The characters act impulsively, driven by hormones and shallow infatuations rather than deep maturity.
- **Betrayal and Loyalty** : Proteus betrays twice, first Julia (Romantic Betrayal) and second, Valentine (Political betrayal).
- **Disguise and Identity** : Julia's disguise as Sebastian explores gender roles and emotional suffering.
- **Forgiveness** : Valentine forgives Proteus too easily, emphasizing mercy over justice.

Symbols

- **Rings**: Rings are exchanged as symbols of promises and fidelity. Proteus's willingness to give away Julia's ring symbolizes his broken vows.
- **Letters**: Letters represent the characters' attempts to communicate their feelings, but they are often torn up, misdirected, or intercepted, symbolizing the misunderstandings inherent in young love.
- **Crab the Dog** : Symbol of true loyalty. More loyal than Proteus.
- **Disguise (Julia as Sebastian)** : Inner against outer identity. It reflects love hidden behind masks.
- **Forest / Outlaws** : Freedom from social laws

IMPORTANT QUOTATIONS (with meaning)

“In love, who respects friend?” – Proteus

→ Shows selfishness and betrayal.

“To leave my Julia, shall I be forsworn?”

→ Proteus' inner conflict.

“My love to Valentine is cold.”

→ Proof of inconstancy.

“O how this spring of love resembleth the uncertain glory of an April day.” – Silvia

→ Love is changeable.

Why is the ending of *The Two Gentlemen of Verona* so controversial, and what does it say about Renaissance values?

The ending is highly controversial because Valentine offers his beloved Silvia to the man who just tried to assault her. To a modern audience, this is jarring and misogynistic. However, the play explores the Renaissance philosophical ideal that true male friendship is the highest form of human connection. Valentine's offer is a supreme sacrifice meant to prove the absolute purity of his forgiveness and friendship. Ultimately, Shakespeare resolves the tension quickly by having Julia reveal herself, allowing both friendship and romantic love to be salvaged without anyone actually having to go through with Valentine's terrible offer.

Discuss Proteus as a character.

Proteus represents inconsistency and moral weakness. Though he begins as Julia's lover and Valentine's friend, he abandons both for Silvia. His betrayal of Valentine by exposing the escape plan proves his selfishness. However, his sudden repentance shows Shakespeare's interest in forgiveness rather than punishment. Proteus serves as a warning against uncontrolled desire.

Compare Julia and Silvia as heroines.

Julia is emotional and patient, while Silvia is bold and outspoken. Julia suffers silently and remains faithful despite Proteus's betrayal. Silvia actively resists Proteus and seeks Valentine. Both represent true love and loyalty, contrasting Proteus's inconstancy.

How is friendship tested in the play?

The friendship between Valentine and Proteus is tested by love. Proteus allows desire to destroy loyalty. Valentine, however, remains honorable even when betrayed. Shakespeare shows that friendship without moral strength cannot survive temptation.

Is the ending satisfactory?

The ending is controversial because Proteus is forgiven too quickly. While this fits the comic tradition of reconciliation, it raises moral questions about justice. Shakespeare emphasizes mercy and harmony rather than realism.

Discuss disguise as a dramatic device.

Julia's disguise as Sebastian creates dramatic irony and emotional tension. It allows her to witness Proteus's betrayal and shows the pain of hidden love. Disguise also explores gender identity and loyalty.